

1.

As a 21 year old, Caucasian, middle class, settled Irish male I am not part of any social group or minority that is prejudiced against or at an obvious disadvantage to others. For this reason I have always considered my educational experience to be ‘normal’ but due to the self-reflection necessary to carry out an Educational Autobiography I am now able, to identify the influence that both my social class and personal family life has had on my educational experience.

The middle-class, Caucasian, settled-Irish characteristics of my family meant that my older brother (3 years my senior) and I were able to attend our local Jesuit bunscoil. Despite its selective admission policies, the school had a strong reputation and its plentiful funding meant that there were ample resources for every student to receive a high quality education. This is in contrast with schools only down the road, where the children of other ethnicities/social classes would attend.

While I was in 6 years old, my parents divorced and they both were quick to re-marry. My brother and I would split our time equally between my grandparents’ and each of my parents’ homes.

I can see now the influence this had on me as a child, as my brother and my classroom were the most consistent aspects of my day-to-day life. This resulted in me mimicking my brother’s views and opinions as my own, as well as becoming introverted and putting a great deal of effort into perfecting my schoolwork from a young age.

Despite my immediate family having no history of third level education, my brother placed great value on it at a young age. At the age of 12, my brother insisted we be enrolled in our local meánscoil lán-Ghaeilge; he recognised that education through the Irish language often goes hand-in-hand with education of a high quality, which then leads to 3rd level. It’s fair to say that this kind of late enrolment wouldn’t have been possible but for my family’s social standing and pre-existing relationships with some of the school staff – sociological factors that shouldn’t, but unfortunately do, have an effect on the quality of education available to most children.

Through hindsight, I can acknowledge the extent of which I mimicked my brother’s views and opinions throughout my school life, ignoring my own educational ambitions. He believed that there was no place for any kind of assistance or community in the education system; everyone is equally capable and individually responsible for their own education, the only thing that stands between a student and the highest mark is putting in effort.

Thanks to the emphasis I placed on doing my own schoolwork to a high standard in primary school, I had a solid foundation in all subjects and found all aspects of school straightforward and easy to do well in. After going through secondary school finding all the subjects easy to comprehend and memorise, I slowly began to take note of how other students were doing around me. I was disappointed to see teachers doing the bare minimum and leaving most of my classmates struggling.

I finally felt obliged in 6th year to form my own view of the education system, which turned out to be nearly polar opposite to my brother’s: I don’t believe that everyone is individually equally capable of greatly organising their entire education, but I believe that a great teacher can ensure that everyone is at the level they need to be, and if they can’t then it’s a shortcoming of the teacher not the student.

Personally, I was confident that I would get the points needed for my course, so felt that any more study for my own subjects would be pointless since most of my class weren't lucky enough to be in a situation where they would have surplus points. So I spent my 6th year helping my classmates in any way that I could. I learnt the syllabus for subjects I'd never done in order to give grinds, helped with projects and portfolios that needed to be finished etc. In the end I got 500 points, and made a significant difference in 20 people's Leaving Cert, in comparison to my brother's 800 points.

Through the undertaking of this Critical Educational Autobiography, I can see what individuals, event and sociological characteristics have influenced my educational experiences and aspirations. I can now clearly identify the reasons for which I'm passionate about becoming a Maths and Irish teacher, the two subjects that students find most difficult.

2.

In my opinion there are three variables that determine an individual's success or failure in school: home life, the student's own personality and the quality of their teachers. Certain home situations can leave students disadvantaged when it comes to attaining success in school. In general the individual's personality must be able to understand the reasons to succeed in school and the consequences of failing, and be willing to put in whatever effort is needed. If there is a situation at home which leaves them disadvantaged then this mental strength needs to be even stronger, so as to be able to prioritise and separate the school and home life from each other.

In my opinion, a teacher should be able to inspire students to this required way of thinking and help the students with external pressures/problems all while effectively teaching the required syllabus. Unfortunately, for reasons such as under-resourced schools, rising class numbers, underpaid teachers etc., all teachers aren't held to the standard of 'great' teachers and I think that is a big factor in why individuals fail or succeed in school.